

The Market Value Reality Check

Are you actually being paid what your experience is worth?

Your title and current salary are starting points. Use these six checks to separate what you know from what you still need to investigate.

Write a specific example or next question under each check. If you do not know, write "research".

01 SCOPE

What do you actually own?

Look beyond your title: decisions, budget, team, complexity and accountability. Where has your role grown?

02 IMPACT

What changes because of your work?

Name a result: revenue, cost, time, risk or customer experience. What did you contribute, and what evidence supports it?

03 MARKET

What are genuinely comparable roles paying?

Find 3 recent roles with similar scope, level and location. Compare base pay separately from bonus, equity and benefits.

04 LEVERAGE

Could someone explain what to recommend you for?

Complete: "I would recommend me for ____ because I have delivered ____." Who could credibly support that recommendation?

05 GAP

What is actually holding your pay back?

Is it a skill gap, weak evidence, low visibility, a smaller role, or an employer pay limit? What evidence would distinguish them?

06 NEXT MOVE

What would you investigate before acting?

Choose a working next step: stay, negotiate, test the market or build evidence. What would make you change your mind?

What does your evidence suggest?

First, check your comparisons. Match actual responsibilities, level, location and industry. Compare base pay with base pay; assess bonus, equity and benefits separately.

Record 3 recent roles or recruiter conversations: source/date, matching scope and pay. If the matches are weak or results conflict, research first. A posted range is not a promised offer.

01

02

03

Look for these signals. More than one may apply.

STAY WITH A PLAN

If you found: Several close matches show similar pay, and your scope fits your level.
Next: Set a review date and a growth goal. Similar pay does not mean the role fits your life.

NEGOTIATE

If you found: Comparable roles pay more, or your scope has grown, and you can show results.
Next: Present that evidence; ask about the pay band, approval process and review timing.

TEST THE MARKET

If you found: A consistent pay gap, but your employer confirms a pay cap or offers no clear path.
Next: Test demand through recruiters and applications before assuming a higher offer is available.

BUILD EVIDENCE

If you found: Better-paid roles require skills or scope you lack, or your results are hard to explain.
Next: Close one skill gap, document one result, or ask an advocate to improve your visibility.

Your next 3 moves

01 One thing to research

Which role, pay range or missing skill will you investigate?

02 One person to talk to

Who can offer market context, candid feedback or a credible recommendation?

03 One piece of evidence to document

Which result will you capture with your contribution and supporting numbers?

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